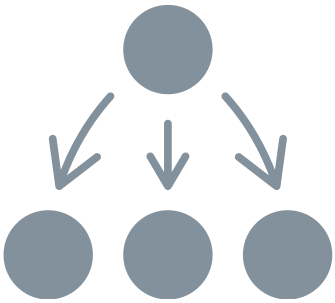
Equip



# DISCIPLESHIP 101

## WHAT is Discipleship

The Greek word- mathētés translates into English as – 'disciple' or 'learner' or 'pupil'. The word disciple itself typically has two aspects to it: the relationship of a student to a teacher, and the notion of following along behind someone. First and foremost, our discipleship is to Jesus Christ, a relationship of being with him and following him (Matt 16:24-25).

In the words of John Stott: "At its simplest, Christ's call was 'Follow me.' He asked men and women for their personal allegiance. He invited them to learn from him, to obey his words and to identify themselves with his cause". In this discipleship process we are being 'transformed' so that we will eventually be 'conformed' to his likeness (Rom 8:29, 2 Cor 3:18).

The verb form 'to disciple', describes the process by which we encourage another person to be such a follower of Jesus; it means the methods we may employ to help that person to grow as a 'learner 'of Christ, to grow towards full maturity in Christ, so they may also in turn disciple someone else (i.e. that they too may become a 'disciple maker').

By using the word 'discipling', Al Stewart best describes this activity as – "more than simply evangelizing unbelievers, discipling is defined as: prayerfully and faithfully building people up until they are mature followers of the Lord Jesus (Col 1:28). Discipling is moving people forward in their knowledge of God; in their commitment to Christ; and in their commitment to serving others". In this regard, true discipleship and disciple making must rightly be understood as a process not a program.

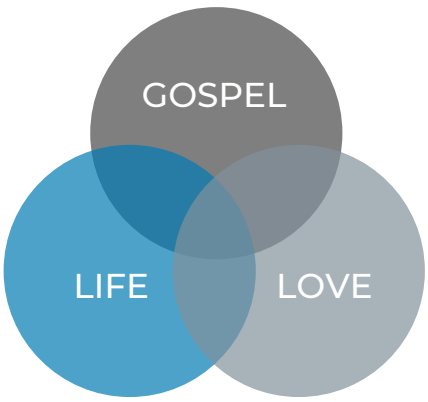
## HOW do we Disciple

*Because we loved you so much, we were delighted to share with you not only the gospel of God but our lives as well.* - 1 Thessalonians 2:8

Discipleship involves *relationship!* It is not systematic or achieved through programs, but *life to life*. First Thessalonians 2:8 describes three areas necessary for authentic discipleship: **Life**, **Love**, and **the Gospel**.

Spend time considering what discipleship would be like if it excluded one of these three areas:

No sharing of **life** = Meaningless
No affection (**love**) of the other = Mechanical
No focus on the **Gospel** = Mentorship



# DISCIPLESHIP 101

## WHAT are we building

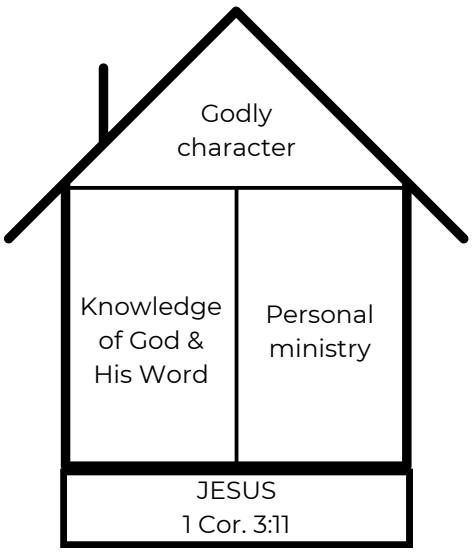
Read 1 Corinthians 3:5-11 and spend time discussing the passage.

- What is the foundation?
- Do all buildings stand the test of time?
- What might make some structures last and others burn up?

Read Romans 15:14, listed below. What is Paul desiring would be established in the life of the believer?

> *I myself am convinced, my brothers and sisters, that you yourselves are **full of goodness**, **filled with knowledge** and **competent to instruct one another**.*

A helpful illustration is a house. The foundation is Christ (1 Cor 3:11). In the verse above, Paul longs to see them be filled with knowledge of God and His Word, and able to instruct one another by understanding how to reproduce their life in another (personal ministry). This is held together by being full of goodness, which is another way to say having exemplary character.




There are many ways to disciple another. Scripture does not give us a detailed roadmap! But it does list important principles for the process.

## PRINCIPLES for Discipleship

Just as Jesus spent signifiant amounts of time with Peter, James and John, so we must spend disproportional amounts of time with a few to make the greatest impact.

Paul reiterates this in 2 Timothy 2:2 when he stresses to Timothy that he is to invest in "reliable" men and women. A helpful acronym is whether they are **FAT** individuals: **Faithful, Available, and Teachable.**

Discipleship involves caring for the whole person! Consider the relationships below and how they relate to discipleship:

- **Counselor** -- While discipleship involves caring for the needs of another, it is more than simple addressing specific needs in their life! Discipleship involves being a **builder** in the life of another, not simply a **doctor** to address the current need.
- **Friend** -- Hopefully a friendship is developed between you and who you are discipling! But discipleship involves more than simply being friends; it's also helping to point them to Jesus and have an **intentional plan** to do so!
- **Mentor** -- It is difficult, if not impossible, to lead somewhere you have not gone yourself. A mentorship is where one person passes along their wisdom and expertise to another. While this may be a part of discipleship, discipleship differs from mentorship in that you are ultimately taking them to the **feet of Jesus** to learn together from God Himself, **guided by the Holy Spirit** in each of your lives!

**Application:** List the names of 1-3 people you might want to begin a discipleship relationship with, and begin praying God would open the door to invest in their life in this way!

This journal was made by the University of Arizona Navigators staff in 2020, with the latest update in 2025, and is meant to be shared. Please do not reproduce for profit.

For reproduction, corrections, suggestions for improvement, or to request a digital copy please email Ryan Mullarkey at ryan.mullarkey@navigators.org